

**LIVE**

Learning Space

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**ITEM WISE EDITORIALS**

**7<sup>th</sup> WEEK**



# LOOK WEST POLICY

**UPSC CSE – GS II**

**GS II ... Effect of Policies and Politics of Developed and Developing Countries on India's Interests, Indian Diaspora.**



# 3

## Expanding horizons

India's West Asia engagement must focus on strengthening its presence as an economic and security partner



HARSH V. PANT

As India seeks to pursue a multi-dimensional engagement with West Asia, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's latest visit to the region has merely underscored its growing salience in the Indian foreign policy matrix. While much focus is often given to India's 'Act East' policy, India's 'Look West' policy too is evolving rapidly. This is Mr. Modi's fifth visit to West Asia in the last three and a half years and sustained high-level engagements have ensured that India's voice is becoming an important one in a region that is witnessing major power rivalries playing out.

Mr. Modi's Palestine visit – and the first visit by an Indian Prime Minister – coming just weeks after Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's high profile visit to India, has been being looked at with significant interest. Underlining India's credentials as a "very respected country in the international arena", Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas had called for a

potential Indian role in the West Asian peace process. "We believe in the importance of a possible Indian role... to reach a final agreement based on international consensus and resolutions," he had suggested before Mr. Modi's visit, but the Prime Minister decided to steer clear of this as the complexities of the region were evident in the very manner of his landing at the Palestinian Authority's presidential headquarters in Ramallah.

In line with New Delhi's policy of trying to build capacity of Palestine, India signed six agreements worth around \$50 million with the Palestinian Authority that include setting up of a super speciality hospital in Beit Sahur, a centre for empowering women, procurement of equipment and machinery for the National Printing Press and significant investment in the education sector. Mr. Abbas also conferred the 'Grand Collar of the State of Palestine' on Mr. Modi in recognition of his key contribution in promoting ties between India and Palestine. Though Mr. Modi said, "India hopes for Palestine to soon emerge a sovereign and independent country in a peaceful atmosphere", he dropped any mention of a "united" and "viable" Palestine in his remarks, in a departure from past practice. His shift is as much about changing



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realities on the ground as it is about New Delhi's evolving priorities.

### Bringing in a focus

India's robust engagements with the Arab Gulf states are a part of this dynamic, with Mr. Modi visiting the United Arab Emirates (UAE) for the second time in the last three years. Trade and economic ties are becoming central to the India-UAE relationship. A landmark pact awarding a consortium of Indian oil companies a 10% stake in offshore oil concession will be the first Indian investment in the UAE's upstream oil sector, transforming a traditional buyer-seller relationship into a long-term investor relationship with stakes in each other's strategic sectors. There was also an MoU aimed at institutionalising the collaborative administration of contractual em-

ployment of Indian workers. In their joint statement, the two countries "reiterated their condemnation for efforts, including by states, to use religion to justify, support and sponsor terrorism against other countries, or to use terrorism as instrument of state policy." There is also growing convergence between the two countries on tackling terrorism.

### Containing China

Oman has been a long-standing partner of India in West Asia, where Indians constitute the largest expatriate community. With the Indian Ocean becoming a priority focus area for New Delhi, Oman's significance is likely to grow. China's expanding footprint in the Indian Ocean Region has alerted India to the possibility of strengthening security ties with littoral states. India is likely to step up its military presence in Oman. Naval cooperation has already been gaining momentum with Muscat giving berthing rights to Indian naval vessels to fight piracy in the Gulf of Aden. Regular naval exercises have now become the norm.

India and Oman have not only made military cooperation more expansive during the Modi visit but also made an attempt to take the relationship to other domains:

by enhancing cooperation in the field of health, tourism and peaceful uses of outer space.

Given the nature of West Asian politics, with sultans and monarchs still holding sway, the Prime Minister's personal diplomacy has indeed had a significant impact in galvanising bilateral relations. But bureaucratic inertia in New Delhi continues to hamper India's outreach. India's engagement with West Asia should now focus on delivering on its commitments and strengthening its presence as an economic and security partner. This will be crucial as traditional powers such as the U.S. and Russia are jostling militarily, even as America's stakes in the region decline by the day. China and India, as two emerging powers, are yet to articulate a clear road map for the region. While India is still stuck in the age-old debates of Israel-Arab rivalry, West Asia has moved on. Growing rivalry between the Sunni Arabs and Shia Iran is reshaping old relationships and India will have to be more pragmatic in its approach towards the region. The Prime Minister's visit has underlined this new reality for India.

Harsh V. Pant is Distinguished Fellow at Observer Research Foundation, New Delhi and Professor at King's College London

## Ramallah recall

Narendra Modi's visit signals India's strategy to grow ties with Israel and Palestine separately

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Palestine underlines the delicate balance New Delhi has adopted in this long-standing and seemingly intractable conflict. India, which has been a champion of the Palestinian people's national aspirations, has built strong ties with Israel in recent years. Last year Mr. Modi became the first Indian Prime Minister to visit Israel; the Ramallah visit has come just weeks after his Israeli counterpart, Benjamin Netanyahu, visited India. On the other hand, late last year India voted along with a vast majority of member-states at the UN General Assembly against U.S. President Donald Trump's decision to recognise Jerusalem as Israel's capital. Last week in Ramallah, the Palestinian National Authority's administrative headquarters, Mr. Modi reiterated India's support for the Palestinian cause, saying it "hopes that Palestine soon becomes a sovereign and independent country in a peaceful atmosphere". Both sides also signed a number of agreements for India-funded projects in the West Bank. India's policy objective is clear and rooted in political realism. It wants to maintain the balance in its relationship with both Palestine and Israel, and strengthen bilateral ties with each separately.

This balance is vital for India, for which Israel is a source of defence equipment and agricultural technology. But Israel also faces political isolation internationally over its occupation of the Palestinian territories and does not have diplomatic ties with most countries in West Asia. As reflected in the UNGA vote, international public opinion is overwhelmingly against the occupation. India, which has vital interests in the Gulf and enjoys good ties with the region's Muslim countries, cannot afford to be seen to be politically closer to Israel at the expense of ties with Palestinians. So it is not a coincidence that the Prime Minister's visit to Palestine took place against the backdrop of India's deepening ties with Israel. With the Ramallah visit, the message Mr. Modi is sending out is that India's partnership with Israel is not at the expense of its principled support for the Palestinian cause. Still, changing nuances in India's position were on display during the visit. Traditionally, India has supported the creation of an independent Palestine within the 1967 borders, with East Jerusalem as its capital. According to this line, Israel would have to withdraw from the West Bank and East Jerusalem and either pull out the Jewish settlements or do a land-swap with the Palestinians as part of a final agreement. Mr. Modi carefully avoided any reference to the borders or to the capital. In effect, India's support for the two-state solution remains, but it has now stopped short of the specifics.

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...Contd.



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## IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

India adopted a realistic "Look West Policy" with continuous engagement with major regional powers in the region. Examine critically.









**United Arab Emirates**



## THERE ARE SEVEN EMIRATES IN UAE

- Abu Dhabi
- Dubai
- Sharjah
- Ajman
- Umm al-Quwain
- Ras al-Khaimah
- Fujairah



# PRIME MINISTER'S VISIT TO UAE

## A SNAPSHOT ON UAE

### HOW IT CONNECTED WITH INDIA?

- ✓ 2.2 million Indians are in UAE, which is around 30% of the Nation's population.
- ✓ Population of UAE is around 9 million, majority of them are expatriates.
- ✓ Foreign remittances amount to around \$ 10 to \$ 12 billion from the expatriates to India.
- ✓ India can tap the Sovereign Wealth Funds of UAE.
- ✓ UAE is one of the largest trading partners with India.

### GEOGRAPHICAL FEATURES

- ✓ It consists of seven Emirates, established in Dec 1971.
- ✓ Abu Dhabi is the capital.
- ✓ Abu Dhabi is the largest and the most populous is Dubai.
- ✓ Islam is the religion.
- ✓ Arabic is the official language.
- ✓ Oil reserves are the 7<sup>th</sup> largest in the world.
- ✓ It is towards the SE of the Arabian Peninsula.
- ✓ Dubai is the vibrant city.
- ✓ Economy is approx. \$ 400 billion.
- ✓ Currency is UAE Dirham.



### DO YOU KNOW?

- *UAE has got the tallest building in the world.*
- *UAE has got Sovereign Wealth Funds of \$ 800 b, one of the largest in the world.*





## PALESTINE / ISRAEL AND INDIA RELATIONS

- 1 India has been a strong votary of Palestinian cause for several decades. At the same time, India built strong ties with Israel in recent years.
- 2 Indian Prime Minister's visit to Ramallah came just weeks after Israel Prime Minister's visit to India.
- 3 The Indian Prime Minister visited Israel last year.
- 4 India voted along with a vast majority of member-states against U.S. President Donald Trump's decision to recognize Jerusalem as Israel's capital.



1

## VISIT TO PALESTINE



**1** This is the first visit by any Indian Prime Minister.

**2** This visit came after India dehyphenated the ties with Israel and Palestine.

**3** India signed six agreements worth around \$ 50 million, which includes setting up of a super speciality hospital and procurement of equipment and machinery for national printing press.

**4** The country conferred “**The Grand Collar of the Nation**” to Mr. Modi.

**5** India hoped for Palestine as a sovereign and independent country in a peaceful atmosphere. But, in the Joint Statement, **no mention of Jerusalem, United and Viable Palestine** and it is a departure from the past practice.



1

## VISIT TO PALESTINE



### SHORT OF THE SPECIFICS THIS TIME

1

Traditionally, India supported the creation of independent Palestine within the 1967 borders, with East Jerusalem as its capital.

2

Israel has to withdraw from the West Bank and East Jerusalem and either pull out the Jewish settlements or do a land-swap with the Palestinians as part of the final agreement. But, our Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi carefully avoided any reference to the borders or to the capital.

***India's support for the two-state solution remains, but it appears, it is short of the specifics. However, India sent a clear message that India's partnership with Israel is not at the expense of its principled support for the Palestinian cause.***





## DELICATE BALANCE ... THE NEED OF THE HOUR

- 1 Israel is a source of defence equipment and agricultural technology.
- 2 Israel also faces political isolation internationally over its occupation of the Palestinian territories.
- 3 It does not have diplomatic ties with most countries in West Asia.
- 4 International public opinion is overwhelmingly against the occupation.



2

## VISIT TO UAE



**1** Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited UAE for the second time in the last three years.

**2** Trade and economic ties are becoming central to UAE relationship.

**3** A land mark pact awarding a consortium of Indian oil companies a 10% stake in offshore oil concession will be the first Indian investment in the UAE's upstream oil sector.

**4** There was also an MoU aimed at institutionalising the collaborative administration of contractual employment of Indian workers.

*There is growing convergence between the two countries in tackling terrorism.*



### 3 VISIT TO OMAN

- 1 Oman has been a long standing partner of India in West Asia.
- 2 Indians constitute largest expatriate community.
- 3 Oman's significance is likely to grow because of Indian Ocean becoming a priority focus area.
- 4 Moreover, China's expanding footprint in IOR alerted India to the possibilities of strengthening security ties.

- 5 Muscat gave birthing rights to Indian Naval Vessels to fight piracy in the Gulf of Aden.
- 6 Regular naval exercises have become the norm.
- 7 In addition to expansion of military cooperation, it also made an attempt to take it to the other domains by enhancing the cooperation in the fields of health, tourism and peaceful uses of outer space.









## WEST ASIA AND CHANGING REALITY

- 1 India's engagement should focus on delivering the commitments and strengthening its presence as an economic and security partner, because USA's stakes in the region are declining day by day.
- 2 China and India as two emerging powers are yet to articulate a clear road map for the region.
- 3 India has to be more pragmatic in its approach towards the region.

***The Prime Minister's visit underlined this new reality for India***

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